

1. Vocabulary

Vocabulary refers to the stock of words a person knows and uses in a language. A strong vocabulary helps in clear communication, better comprehension, and effective writing and speaking.

Words are best remembered when they are learned in groups (word families) rather than in isolation. For example, learning 'act', 'react', 'action', 'active' together builds a stronger mental link than learning each word separately.

Ways to Build Vocabulary

- Reading newspapers, novels and journals regularly
- Learning synonyms and antonyms of new words
- Understanding root words, prefixes and suffixes
- Using a dictionary/thesaurus to check meaning and usage
- Using new words in sentences to remember them

 *Shortcut: To guess the meaning of an unfamiliar word quickly, break it into Prefix + Root + Suffix. 'Unbelievable' = Un (not) + believe (root) + able (capable of) = 'not able to be believed'.*

Key Terms

Term	Meaning / Example
Synonym	A word with the same/similar meaning (e.g., happy – glad)
Antonym	A word with the opposite meaning (e.g., happy – sad)
Homonym	Words that sound alike but differ in meaning/spelling (e.g., bear – bare)
Root word	The base word to which prefixes/suffixes are added (e.g., 'act' in react, action)

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

1. The word 'un_____' means 'not happy'. (happy)
2. A word that means the same as another is called a _____.
3. 'Dis' in 'disagree' is an example of a _____.
4. The opposite of 'genuine' is _____.

B. Choose the Best Answer

1. Choose the synonym of 'Intelligent':
(a) Dull (b) Clever (c) Slow (d) Weak
2. Choose the antonym of 'Beautiful':
(a) Pretty (b) Ugly (c) Lovely (d) Charming
3. Which word is a homonym pair?
(a) big – large (b) bear – bare (c) hot – cold (d) run – walk

C. Match the Following

Column A	Column B
1. Diligent	(a) Strong and healthy
2. Benevolent	(b) Honest and frank
3. Candid	(c) Hardworking
4. Robust	(d) Kind and generous

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – unhappy, synonym, prefix, fake. Choose the Best – b, b, b. Match the Following – 1–c, 2–d, 3–b, 4–a.

2. Idioms and Phrases

An idiom is a group of words whose meaning cannot be understood from the literal meaning of the individual words. Idioms add colour and expressiveness to language.

A phrase is a small group of words that gives a particular meaning, but unlike a sentence, it does not contain a subject and a verb together.

Common Idioms and Their Meanings

Idiom	Meaning
Break the ice	To start a conversation in a social setting
Once in a blue moon	Very rarely
Hit the books	To study hard
A piece of cake	Something very easy to do
Burn the midnight oil	To work/study late into the night
Under the weather	Feeling slightly ill

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

1. She was _____ (under the weather) and stayed home from college.
2. Passing that easy quiz was _____ (a piece of cake) for him.
3. We only meet our cousins _____ (once in a blue moon).
4. He had to _____ (hit the books) before the final exam.

B. Choose the Best Answer

1. 'Break the ice' means:
(a) To break something fragile (b) To start a conversation (c) To end a friendship (d) To feel cold
2. 'Burn the midnight oil' means:
(a) To waste fuel (b) To sleep early (c) To work/study late at night (d) To light a lamp
3. Choose the idiom that means 'very rarely':
(a) A piece of cake (b) Once in a blue moon (c) Hit the books (d) Break the ice

C. True or False

1. 'A piece of cake' refers to something difficult to do. (True / False)
2. 'Under the weather' means feeling slightly ill. (True / False)
3. 'Hit the books' means to damage a book. (True / False)
4. 'Break the ice' is used to describe starting a conversation. (True / False)

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – under the weather, a piece of cake, once in a blue moon, hit the books. Choose the Best – b, c, b. Match the Following – 1–False, 2–True, 3–False, 4–True.

3. Antonyms

An antonym is a word that means the opposite of another word. Antonyms are important for improving vocabulary, comprehension and for competitive examinations.

Recognising the antonym 'type' helps you answer faster in exams — graded antonyms allow a middle state, while complementary antonyms are strictly either/or.

Types of Antonyms

- Graded antonyms – have a scale between them (e.g., hot – cold, with warm in between)
- Complementary antonyms – no middle ground (e.g., true – false, alive – dead)
- Relational antonyms – imply a relationship (e.g., teacher – student, buy – sell)

 **Shortcut:** Ask 'Is there anything in between?' If yes (hot – warm – cold), it's a graded antonym. If no (alive – dead), it's complementary. If the two words depend on each other (buy – sell, teacher – student), it's relational.

Examples

Word	Antonym
Ancient	Modern
Brave	Cowardly
Genuine	Fake
Generous	Stingy
Victory	Defeat
Increase	Decrease

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

1. The antonym of 'Ancient' is _____.
2. The antonym of 'Brave' is _____.
3. The antonym of 'Victory' is _____.
4. 'Hot – Cold' is an example of a _____ antonym (graded/complementary).

B. Choose the Best Answer

1. Choose the correct antonym of 'Generous':
(a) Kind (b) Stingy (c) Rich (d) Helpful
2. Choose the correct antonym of 'Genuine':
(a) Real (b) Original (c) Fake (d) True
3. 'Alive – Dead' is an example of:
(a) Graded antonym (b) Complementary antonym (c) Relational antonym (d) Synonym pair

C. Short Answer

1. State whether 'teacher–student' is a graded, complementary, or relational antonym pair.
2. Give one example each of a graded and a complementary antonym pair.
3. Why is 'true–false' considered a complementary antonym and not a graded one?

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – Modern, Cowardly, Defeat, graded. Choose the Best – b, c, b.

4. Rearranging Jumbled Words into Meaningful Sentences

This exercise tests the understanding of correct English sentence structure. A standard English sentence follows the pattern: Subject + Verb + Object (S + V + O).

Time and place expressions usually come at the end of the sentence, in that order (Time, then Manner, then Place is one common guideline, though 'place before time' is also frequent — always read the rearranged sentence aloud to check it sounds natural).

Steps to Rearrange Jumbled Words

- Identify the subject (who/what the sentence is about)
- Identify the verb (the action or state)
- Identify the object/complement (who/what receives the action)
- Place adverbs/adjectives/prepositional phrases in their natural position
- Read the rearranged sentence aloud to check if it makes sense

Example

Jumbled: market / she / vegetables / bought / from / the

Rearranged: She bought vegetables from the market.

 *Shortcut: First circle the verb (action word) in the jumbled list — it anchors the sentence. Then ask 'Who/What does this action?' to find the subject, and 'To whom/what?' to find the object. Everything else (adjectives, adverbs, prepositional phrases) slots around this S-V-O core.*

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

1. Rearrange and fill: 'quickly / he / runs' → He _____ quickly.
2. Rearrange and fill: 'book / reading / is / she / a' → She is reading a _____.
3. Rearrange and fill: 'school / to / went / they' → They went _____ school.
4. Rearrange and fill: 'letter / wrote / a / he' → He wrote a _____.

B. Choose the Best Answer

1. Which is the correctly rearranged sentence for 'homework / every day / his / does / he'?
(a) He does every day his homework. (b) He does his homework every day. (c) Every day does he his homework. (d) His homework every day he does.
2. Which is the correctly rearranged sentence for 'quickly / ran / boy / the / school / to'?
(a) The boy ran quickly to school. (b) Quickly the boy to school ran. (c) To school ran the boy quickly. (d) The boy to school quickly ran.
3. In an S+V+O sentence, which part usually comes first?
(a) Object (b) Verb (c) Subject (d) Adverb

C. Rearrange the Following (Write the Full Sentence)

1. letter / a / wrote / to / friend / she / her
2. is / today / weather / pleasant / the / very
3. carefully / the / read / instructions / students / the

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – runs, book, to, letter. Choose the Best – b, a, c.

5. Error Correction

Error correction tests the ability to identify and correct grammatical mistakes in a sentence. Common errors occur in tense, subject-verb agreement, articles, prepositions, and word order.

Most exam sentences contain only one deliberate error, so scan tense, then subject-verb agreement, then articles/prepositions in that order — the mistake is usually in one of these three areas.

 **Shortcut:** Read the sentence and ask three quick checks — (1) Does the verb tense match the time word (yesterday, tomorrow)? (2) Does the verb agree with a singular/plural subject? (3) Is 'a' used before a consonant sound and 'an' before a vowel sound?

Common Types of Errors

Type of Error	Example (Incorrect → Correct)
Tense error	He go to school yesterday. → He went to school yesterday.
Subject-verb agreement	She do her work. → She does her work.
Article error	He is a honest man. → He is an honest man.
Preposition error	He is good in English. → He is good at English.
Plural/Singular error	I have two informations. → I have two pieces of information.

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

- 'He don't like tea' → He _____ like tea.
- 'She is a MA student' → She is _____ MA student.
- 'Each of the boys have a bag' → Each of the boys _____ a bag.
- 'He is married with a doctor' → He is married _____ a doctor.

B. Choose the Best Answer

- Identify the correct sentence:
(a) He go to school yesterday. (b) He goes to school yesterday. (c) He went to school yesterday.
(d) He going to school yesterday.
- Identify the correct sentence:
(a) She do her work. (b) She does her work. (c) She doing her work. (d) She did do her work.
- Choose the correct article: 'He is ___ honest man.'
(a) a (b) an (c) the (d) no article needed

C. Identify and Correct the Error

1. 'I have two informations about the topic.'
2. 'She don't know the answer.'
3. 'He is good in Mathematics.'

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – doesn't, an, has, to. Choose the Best – c, b, b.

6. Prepositions

A preposition is a word placed before a noun or pronoun to show its relationship with another word in the sentence — usually relating to place, time, direction, or manner.

The same preposition can express different relationships depending on context, so it helps to learn common fixed phrases (good at, married to, afraid of) as whole chunks rather than translating word-for-word.

Types of Prepositions

Type	Common Words & Examples
Preposition of Time	at, on, in, since, for, during — e.g., 'at 6 PM', 'on Monday', 'in June'
Preposition of Place	at, on, in, above, below, near — e.g., 'at the door', 'on the table'
Preposition of Direction	to, into, towards, across, through — e.g., 'walk into the room'
Preposition of Manner	by, with, like — e.g., 'travel by bus', 'write with a pen'

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

1. She arrived _____ (at/in) 9 o'clock.
2. The cat is sitting _____ (on/under) the table.
3. He is good _____ (at/in) Mathematics.
4. They travelled _____ (by/with) train to Chennai.

B. Choose the Best Answer

1. Choose the correct preposition: 'The meeting is ____ Monday.'
(a) at (b) on (c) in (d) by
2. Choose the correct preposition: 'He walked ____ the room.'
(a) into (b) at (c) on (d) since
3. Choose the correct preposition: 'She is afraid ____ spiders.'
(a) at (b) of (c) with (d) for

C. Match the Following

Column A	Column B
1. at	(a) manner (travel by bus)
2. since	(b) direction (walked into the room)
3. into	(c) precise point in time (at 6 PM)
4. by	(d) starting point in time (since 2020)

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – at, on, at, by. Choose the Best – b, a, b. Match the Following – 1–c, 2–d, 3–b, 4–a.

7. Active and Passive Voice

Voice indicates whether the subject of a sentence performs the action (Active Voice) or receives the action (Passive Voice).

Active Voice: Subject + Verb + Object — e.g., 'The teacher teaches the students.' Passive Voice: Object + be-verb + Past Participle + by + Subject — e.g., 'The students are taught by the teacher.'

Rule for Conversion

Object of active sentence becomes the subject of the passive sentence; the verb changes to 'be + past participle'; and 'by + subject' may be added at the end.

 **Shortcut:** To convert Active to Passive in 3 moves — (1) Object of the active sentence jumps to the front and becomes the new subject, (2) the verb changes to the matching form of 'be' + past participle (V3), (3) 'by + old subject' goes at the end. Tense of 'be' must match the original tense.

Examples

Voice	Sentence
Active	Ram writes a letter.
Passive	A letter is written by Ram.
Active	The cat chased the mouse.
Passive	The mouse was chased by the cat.

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

- Active: She cooks food. → Passive: Food _____ (is cooked/was cooked) by her.
- Active: They built the bridge. → Passive: The bridge _____ (was built) by them.
- Passive: The book was read by him. → Active: He _____ (read) the book.

4. Active: The manager will sign the letter. → Passive: The letter _____ (will be signed) by the manager.

B. Choose the Best Answer

- Choose the correct passive form of 'She cooks food.'
(a) Food cooked by her. (b) Food is cooked by her. (c) Food was cooking by her. (d) Food cooks by her.
- Choose the correct passive form of 'They built the bridge.'
(a) The bridge is built by them. (b) The bridge built by them. (c) The bridge was built by them. (d) The bridge builds by them.
- Choose the correct active form of 'The mouse was chased by the cat.'
(a) The cat chases the mouse. (b) The cat chased the mouse. (c) The cat is chasing the mouse. (d) The cat will chase the mouse.

C. Convert the Voice

- Change into passive voice: 'The manager will sign the letter.'
- Change into active voice: 'The homework was completed by the students.'
- Change into passive voice: 'The chef is preparing dinner.'

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – is cooked, was built, read, will be signed. Choose the Best – b, c, b.

8. Direct and Indirect Speech

Direct Speech reports the exact words spoken by a person, enclosed in quotation marks. Indirect (Reported) Speech conveys the meaning of what was said without quoting the exact words.

The choice of connector depends on sentence type: use 'that' for statements, 'if/whether' for yes-no questions, and the question word itself (what, where, why) for wh-questions.

Key Changes While Converting

- Remove quotation marks and use a connector — 'that' for statements, 'if/whether' for yes-no questions (e.g., He said, "I am tired." → He said that he was tired.)
- Change pronouns according to the subject/object of reporting (e.g., "I am happy," she said. → She said that she was happy — 'I' becomes 'she')
- Change the tense of the verb, usually one step back — 'backshift' (e.g., "I play" → he said he played; "I will go" → he said he would go)
- Change time and place words (e.g., today → that day, here → there, tomorrow → the next day)

 **Shortcut** — the 'one step back' rule: when the reporting verb is in the past tense (said), shift the tense one step back — present → past, past → past perfect, 'will' → 'would', 'can' → 'could'. Also shift time/place words: today→that day, here→there, tomorrow→the next day.

Examples

Speech	Sentence
Direct	She said, "I am happy."
Indirect	She said that she was happy.
Direct	He said, "I will go tomorrow."
Indirect	He said that he would go the next day.

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

1. Direct: He said, "I am reading a book." → Indirect: He said that he _____ (was reading) a book.
2. Direct: She said, "I went to the market yesterday." → Indirect: She said that she _____ (had gone) to the market the day before.
3. Indirect: He said that he was tired. → Direct: He said, "I _____ (am) tired."
4. 'Tomorrow' in direct speech becomes _____ in indirect speech.

B. Choose the Best Answer

1. Choose the correct indirect speech for: He said, "I am reading a book."
(a) He said that he is reading a book. (b) He said that he was reading a book. (c) He said that he read a book. (d) He said that he reads a book.
2. Which connector is used to report a yes/no question?
(a) that (b) if/whether (c) because (d) since
3. 'Here' in direct speech usually becomes ____ in indirect speech.
(a) there (b) here (c) where (d) that place

C. Convert the Speech

1. Change into indirect speech: The teacher said, "The earth revolves around the sun."
2. Change into direct speech: She said that she would come the next day.
3. Change into indirect speech: He said, "I have finished my homework."

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – was reading, had gone, am, the next day. Choose the Best – b, b, a.

9. Subject–Verb Agreement

Subject–verb agreement means that the subject and verb in a sentence must agree in number (singular/plural) and person (first/second/third).

With 'or/nor/either...or/neither...nor', the verb always agrees with the subject nearer to it — this is one of the most frequently tested rules.

Important Rules

- A singular subject takes a singular verb; a plural subject takes a plural verb — e.g., 'He plays.' / 'They play.'
- Two subjects joined by 'and' usually take a plural verb — e.g., 'Ram and Shyam are friends.'
- Subjects joined by 'or/nor/either...or/neither...nor' agree with the nearer subject — e.g., 'Either the boys or Ravi is at fault.' (verb agrees with 'Ravi', the nearer subject)
- Collective nouns (team, family, class) usually take a singular verb when acting as one unit — e.g., 'The team is playing well.'
- Indefinite pronouns like each, everyone, nobody take a singular verb — e.g., 'Everyone has submitted the assignment.'

	Sentence
Incorrect	Each of the students have a book.
Correct	Each of the students has a book.
Incorrect	The team are playing well.
Correct	The team is playing well.

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

1. 'Neither of the boys _____ (was/were) present.'
2. 'The news _____ (is/are) shocking.'
3. 'Everybody _____ (is/are) happy today.'
4. 'My brother and my sister _____ (is/are) coming.'

B. Choose the Best Answer

1. Choose the correct verb: 'Each of the students ____ a book.'
(a) have (b) has (c) having (d) had have
2. Choose the correct verb: 'Either the manager or the staff ____ responsible.'
(a) is (b) are (c) be (d) being
3. Choose the correct verb: 'The team ____ playing well.'
(a) is (b) are (c) were (d) have

C. Correct the Sentence

1. 'Everybody are happy today.'
2. 'The jury have given its verdict.' (state whether correct or incorrect, and why)
3. 'Neither of the answers were correct.'

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – was, is, is, are. Choose the Best – b, a, a.

10 (i). One-Word Substitution

One-word substitution means replacing a group of words or a phrase with a single word that conveys the same meaning. This tests precision in vocabulary usage.

Many one-word substitutes follow recognisable patterns: '-phile' means 'one who loves' (bibliophile), '-ist' means 'one who studies/practises' (ornithologist), and 'a-' at the start often means 'without' (atheist = without belief in God).

 *Shortcut: Learn substitutes in themed groups — places (library, sanctuary, orphanage), people (bibliophile, ornithologist, misanthrope), and 'one who cannot/does not' phrases (illiterate, atheist, teetotaler) — grouping by pattern makes recall faster in exams.*

Examples

Phrase	One Word
A person who loves books	Bibliophile
A place where books are kept	Library
One who cannot read or write	Illiterate
A person who studies birds	Ornithologist
One who does not believe in God	Atheist
A short walk for pleasure	Stroll

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

1. A person who travels from place to place is called a _____.
2. One who is easily deceived is called _____.
3. A place where animals are kept for public viewing is a _____.
4. A person who studies birds is called an _____.

B. Choose the Best Answer

1. Choose the correct one-word substitute for 'a person who loves books':
(a) Librarian (b) Bibliophile (c) Author (d) Editor
2. Choose the correct one-word substitute for 'one who does not believe in God':
(a) Theist (b) Atheist (c) Optimist (d) Pessimist
3. Choose the correct one-word substitute for 'a short walk for pleasure':
(a) Sprint (b) Stroll (c) Marathon (d) Jog

C. Give the One-Word Substitute

1. A person who cannot read or write.
2. A place where books are kept.
3. One who leaves one's country to settle in another.

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – wanderer/traveller, gullible, zoo, ornithologist. Choose the Best – b, b, b.

10 (ii). Vocabulary

This section reinforces vocabulary skills through synonym/antonym identification, word usage, and contextual meaning — building on the concepts covered in Topic 1.

In competitive exams, synonym/antonym questions are usually answered fastest by first eliminating options that mean something close to the opposite of what is required, rather than trying to define the given word in full.

 **Shortcut:** When unsure of a word's exact meaning, judge its 'tone' — is it a generally positive word (abundant, optimistic) or negative (scarce, pessimistic)? Match the tone of the correct option to the tone of the question word.

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

1. The synonym of 'Abundant' is _____.
2. The antonym of 'Optimistic' is _____.
3. 'Frugal' means a person who is _____ (careful/wasteful) with money.
4. The synonym of 'Frugal' is _____ (economical/lavish).

B. Choose the Best Answer

1. Find the synonym of 'Abundant':
(a) Scarce (b) Plenty (c) Little (d) Rare
2. Find the antonym of 'Optimistic':
(a) Hopeful (b) Pessimistic (c) Cheerful (d) Confident
3. Give the meaning of the word 'Frugal':
(a) Extravagant (b) Careful with money (c) Generous (d) Wealthy

C. Short Answer

1. Use the word 'meticulous' in a sentence of your own.
2. Give one synonym and one antonym for the word 'Robust'.
3. Explain, in one line, the difference between 'frugal' and 'stingy'.

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – plenty, pessimistic, careful, economical. Choose the Best – b, b, b.

11 (a). Grammar Questions – Prepositions, Nouns, Adverbs, Subject-Verb Agreement

This section combines four core grammar areas frequently tested together: prepositions, nouns, adverbs, and subject–verb agreement.

i. Prepositions

Words showing the relation of a noun/pronoun to another word (place, time, direction). See Topic 6 for full theory.

ii. Nouns

A noun is a word that names a person, place, thing, or idea. Nouns can be:

- Common noun – general name (boy, city)
- Proper noun – specific name (Ravi, Chennai)
- Collective noun – group (team, family)
- Abstract noun – idea/quality (honesty, happiness)
- Countable/Uncountable noun – (book/books; water, sugar)

iii. Adverbs

An adverb modifies a verb, adjective, or another adverb, and usually answers how, when, where, or to what extent.

- Adverb of manner – slowly, carefully, quickly
- Adverb of time – now, yesterday, soon
- Adverb of place – here, there, everywhere
- Adverb of frequency – always, never, often

iv. Subject–Verb Agreement

See Topic 9 for full theory and rules.

 *Shortcut — the 4-question scan: for any sentence, quickly ask (1) Is there a preposition showing place/time/direction? (2) Is the noun common/proper/collective/abstract? (3) Does an adverb tell how/when/where/how often? (4) Does the verb agree with its subject? This scan covers most 2-mark grammar questions in one pass.*

Practice Exercises (Multiple Styles)

A. Fill in the Blanks

1. He is afraid _____ dogs.
2. 'The team celebrated its victory' — 'team' is a _____ noun.
3. 'She sings beautifully' — the adverb in this sentence is _____.
4. 'Honesty' is an example of an _____ noun.

B. Choose the Best Answer

1. Choose the correct preposition: 'He is afraid ____ dogs.'
(a) of (b) at (c) with (d) for
2. Identify the type of noun: 'team' in 'The team celebrated its victory.'
(a) Proper noun (b) Abstract noun (c) Collective noun (d) Common noun
3. Choose the correct verb: 'Either the manager or the staff ____ responsible.'
(a) is (b) are (c) be (d) am

C. Identify and Classify

1. Identify the adverb in the sentence: 'She sings beautifully.'
2. Classify the noun 'honesty' as concrete or abstract.
3. Identify the type of adverb in 'They arrived here yesterday' (name both adverbs and their types).

Answers: Fill in the Blanks – of, collective, beautifully, abstract. Choose the Best – a, c, a.